Guitar Exercises - Section XIII, Level 92

Rakes, Grace Notes, Double-Stop Slides, Harmonics, Volume Swells, Muted Attacks, and Articulation Chains

Level 92 of the fixed 105-level core curriculum. HARD STOP after Level 105.

Level 91 established pitch and timing control for bends and vibrato. Level 92 expands the expressive palette while preserving a strict hierarchy: phrase meaning first, articulation second.

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	TOTAL	1328

Core rule: an articulation is successful only if removing it leaves a phrase that still makes musical sense.

Reference - Articulation Symbols and Priorities

Symbol	Meaning	Primary control
r	rake / muted lead-in	muting + directional sweep
gr	grace note	timing + quick resolution
/ or \	slide	arrival pitch + note length
h / p	hammer-on / pull-off	even volume
<>	natural harmonic	touch point + release
PH	pinch harmonic	pick/thumb contact point
sw	volume swell	remove initial attack
x	dead/muted contact	percussive texture without pitch

Priority order: target pitch -> rhythmic placement -> dynamic level -> articulation detail.

Module A - Rakes and Muted Lead-In Attacks

A rake is a controlled sweep across muted strings into one pitched target. The muted strings must not reveal chord tones.

Cell	Direction	Target	Rule
1	low-to-high	B-string target	3 muted strings + target
2	low-to-high	high-e target	4 muted strings + target
3	high-to-low	G-string target	2 muted strings + target
4	low-to-high	bent target	rake ends before bend begins
5	low-to-high	vibrato target	vibrato begins after pitch centers
6	single muted contact	target on next 16th	micro-rake
7	two muted contacts	target on beat	pickup rake
8	silent rest -> rake	target on beat 4	dramatic entry

Practice on one target note in three registers before changing pitches.

Module A - Rake Dynamic Hierarchy

Pass	Muted contacts	Target
1	pp	mf
2	p	f
3	mp	mf
4	crescendo across rake	f target
5	equal contacts	diagnostic only - should sound too flat
6	near-silent rake	single clear target

The rake is preparation. The target is the musical event.

Module B - Grace Notes, Slides, and Hammer/Pull Ornaments

Cell	Figure	Goal
1	gr below -> target	chromatic lower grace note
2	gr above -> target	chromatic upper grace note
3	whole-step slide into target	arrival exactly on beat
4	half-step slide into target	short vocal-like inflection
5	hammer-on into chord tone	target louder than grace
6	pull-off into chord tone	source does not overpower target
7	grace + slide	two-stage approach
8	slide + delayed vibrato	separate arrival from vibrato

First play the target alone. Then add exactly one ornament. If the target becomes rhythmically unclear, shorten the ornament.

Module B - Ornament Timing Windows

Window	Ornament begins	Target lands
Before beat 1	late beat 4 / &4	beat 1
Inside beat 1	1	&1
Late beat 2	&2 or a2	beat 3
Pickup	&4	next beat 1
Delayed ornament	target first	ornament after sustain
No ornament	rest	target only

Alternate ornamented and unornamented versions so phrasing does not become dependent on constant decoration.

Module C - Double-Stop Slides

Cell	Shape	Motion
1	major 3rd dyad	slide up 2 frets
2	minor 3rd dyad	slide down 2 frets
3	6th dyad	slide up 2 frets, hold
4	4th dyad	slide into resolution dyad
5	same top note	lower voice slides
6	same lower note	upper voice slides
7	both voices move, staggered release	top sustains longer
8	slide -> one voice bends	combined articulation

Keep both notes audible during the slide unless the exercise explicitly isolates one moving voice.

Module C - Double-Stop Release Control

Pass	Top voice	Lower voice
1	release together	release together
2	hold	release early
3	release early	hold
4	slide top only	hold lower
5	hold top	slide lower
6	both slide; top gets vibrato	lower stays centered

This is a voice-leading exercise, not merely a two-note lick.

Module D - Natural Harmonics

Node	Approximate result	Practice
12th fret	octave	E-A-D-G-B-e ascending/descending
7th fret	octave + fifth	all six strings
5th fret	two octaves	all six strings
4th/9th area	higher partials	selected strings only
12th -> 7th -> 5th	node ladder	same string
harmonic -> fretted note	contrast	match dynamic

Touch directly over the fret wire, pick, then remove the fretting finger immediately so the harmonic can ring.

Module E - Pinch Harmonic Calibration

Pinch harmonics depend on pick-hand position relative to the vibrating string length. Move the picking hand gradually rather than squeezing harder.

Cell	Fretted note	Pick-hand task
1	low E 5th fret	scan near bridge until harmonic speaks
2	A string 7th	repeat scan
3	D string 7th	match normal-note volume
4	G string 7th	find two different harmonic nodes
5	B string 8th	soft PH
6	same note normal vs PH	alternate without tempo change
7	PH + vibrato	add only after harmonic sustains
8	PH target in phrase	one harmonic per 4 bars

Avoid excessive thumb contact that chokes the note. The harmonic should bloom, not collapse.

Module F - Volume Swells

Cell	Attack method	Volume motion
1	pick with volume at zero	0 -> full over 1 beat
2	pick at zero	0 -> full over 2 beats
3	pick at zero	0 -> full -> 0 in 2 beats
4	chord swell	0 -> full over 4 beats
5	harmonic swell	natural harmonic + 2-beat swell
6	slide under swell	slide occurs while attack is hidden
7	two-note dyad swell	both voices remain balanced
8	swell into next chord	peak at chord change

Use guitar volume knob, volume pedal, or another controllable volume device. The essential skill is removing the pick transient while preserving rhythmic arrival.

Module G - Muted Attacks and Percussive Lead Texture

Cell	Pattern	Function
1	x target x target	percussive framing
2	xx target	pickup
3	target xx target	space between statements
4	x x slide-target	percussive lead-in
5	rake -> target -> x	strong entry / clipped exit
6	harmonic -> x -> target	texture contrast
7	swell -> x -> target	soft-to-hard contrast
8	target -> rest -> x -> rest	negative-space control

Muted texture should reinforce rhythm without becoming a substitute for phrase content.

Module H - Multi-Articulation Phrase Chains

Chain	Articulation order	Primary risk
Chain 1	rake -> bend -> delayed vibrato	single dramatic target
Chain 2	grace -> slide -> target	compact vocal inflection
Chain 3	double-stop slide -> staggered release	two-voice motion
Chain 4	natural harmonic -> swell	attackless color
Chain 5	pinch harmonic -> wide vibrato	high-intensity accent
Chain 6	muted pickup -> slide -> bend	rhythmic-to-pitched build
Chain 7	pre-bend -> release -> rake answer	tension/release
Chain 8	swell -> target -> grace-note answer	soft entry / articulated response

Play each chain slowly enough that every stage can be heard as intentional. Then remove one articulation and decide whether the phrase improves.

Module H - Phrase-Function Assignment

Function	Recommended chain
Question	grace -> slide -> target
Answer	rake -> bend -> vibrato
Climax	pinch harmonic -> wide vibrato
Resolution	swell -> sustained target
Transition	double-stop slide -> release
Pickup	muted pickup -> slide -> target
Space	natural harmonic or rest
Ending	pre-bend release or volume swell

Articulation should reinforce phrase function. Do not choose the most dramatic technique automatically.

Module I - Thirty-Two-Bar Expressive Texture Capstone

Bars	Harmony	Expression focus	Dynamic
1-4	Am7-Dm7-E7-Am7	rakes + grace notes	mp
5-8	A7-D7-A7-E7	double-stop slides	mf
9-12	Cmaj7-Am7-Dm7-G7	natural harmonics + swells	p
13-16	E5-G5-A5-E5	pinch harmonics	f
17-20	Am7-E7-Am7-Am7	muted lead textures	mf
21-24	G-D-Em-C	mixed articulation chains	mf -> f
25-28	Cmaj7-A7-Dm7-G7	swell/slide contrast	mp
29-32	Am7-Dm7-E7-Am7	reduction and outro	f -> pp

Pass 1: targets only. Pass 2: one articulation per bar. Pass 3: articulation chains. Pass 4: reduce density by 50% while preserving expression. Pass 5: record one uninterrupted take.

Module J - Recovery, Mastery, and Roadmap

Failure	Immediate repair
Rake reveals pitches	mute harder; reduce number of strings
Grace note steals beat	shorten ornament; target lands on grid
Double-stop slide smears	slow slide; reduce pressure
Natural harmonic weak	move touch point directly over fret wire
Pinch harmonic chokes	reduce thumb contact; move pick position
Swell exposes pick attack	start from lower volume / close volume faster
Articulation chain feels crowded	remove one technique
Form lost	targets only until next 4-bar boundary

Mastery: 14/16 or better on two separate days across rake control, ornament timing, double-stop clarity, harmonic production, volume-swell timing, phrase-function choice, density control, and recovery. No zero in target timing, harmonic clarity, phrase-function choice, or recovery.

Next: Level 93 develops compound expressive phrasing: bend/vibrato combinations, double-stop bends, harmonic punctuation, pick/finger tonal contrast, controlled feedback concepts, and long-form articulation arcs.

Fixed roadmap: 91-94 Advanced Expression; 95-99 Repertoire Integration; 100-104 Composition; 105 Final Musicianship Capstone. HARD STOP after 105.